

SAKSHI BHALLA

Institute of Communications Research (ICR), University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign

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EDUCATION	PhD in Media & Communications University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign Honors: <i>Phi Kappa Phi</i>	2021–present Champaign, IL
	Master of Science in Statistics University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign	2025 Champaign, IL
	Master of Arts in Linguistics Jawaharlal Nehru University JNU Entrance Test: <i>All India Rank 1</i> Thesis: <i>Sociolinguistic Profile of Ahirani</i> (a previously-undocumented language spoken in Maharashtra, India)	2018–2020 New Delhi, India
	Bachelor of Arts, with Honors in Journalism Lady Shri Ram College for Women, University of Delhi	2012–2015 New Delhi, India
RESEARCH	Political communication, Information environments, Computational methods	
RESEARCH APPOINTMENTS	Amazon Inc. Research Scientist - PhD Intern	May–Aug 2026 Arlington, VA
PEER-REVIEWED ARTICLES	(4) Ray, R., S. Bhalla & H. Taneja. (2026). Fact checkers are seldom used by news users on either side of the partisan divide. <i>Journal of Communication</i> . doi:10.1093/joc/jqaf018	
	(3) Bhalla, S. , M. Nelson & M. Spikes. (2025). Classroom Contexts: Teachers Talk Teaching Media Literacy. <i>Journal of Media Literacy Education</i> . doi:10.23860/JMLE-2025-17-2-3	
	(2) Bhalla, S. , R. Ray & H. Taneja. (2024). When news is entertainment: Explaining the persistence of misinformation through the information environment. <i>Information, Communication & Society</i> . doi:10.1080/1369118X.2024.2406819	
	(1) Khan, A., S. Natarajan, & S. Bhalla . (2021). Climate Strikes in Millennial India: Social Capital and “On-Ground” Networks in Digital-First Movements. <i>Communication, Culture & Critique</i> . doi:10.1093/cc/cab035	
BOOK CHAPTERS	Bhalla, S. & H. Taneja. (2025). User-defined Repertoires. In Nai, A., Grömping, M., & Wirz, D. (Eds). <i>Elgar Encyclopedia of Political Communication</i> . Edward Elgar Publishing.	

OPEN-SOURCE SOFTWARE	Bhalla, S. breakingnews : Parameter-Efficient LLM Adaptation for Segmenting Broadcast Transcripts. doi:10.5281/zenodo.21863477	2026
WORK IN PROGRESS	Read All Around It: The Regional Organization of Newspaper Markets <i>In preparation</i> Following the News: Polarization and the Networked Structure of Attention <i>In preparation</i> Complements or competitors? Examining human-AI interactions on Sina Weibo <i>In preparation</i> ; with Maggie Zhang	
AWARDS & FELLOWSHIPS	Top Paper Prize, International Communication Association	2026
	Illinois Distinguished Fellowship (\$75,000)	2021–25
	Bart A. Cummings Grant (\$1,200)	2025
	Political Networks Graduate Student Fellowship	2025
	ICA Political Communication Section Travel Grant	2025
	Methodology Center Summer Institute Scholarship (Full support), Purdue University / National Institute on Drug Addiction	2025
	SPARK Award for Promising Graduate Students, American Political Science Association (Political Communication Section)	2024
	Local Journalism Researchers Workshop Travel Grant, Duke University	2024
	National Center for Supercomputing Applications (750,000 × 2 core hours)	2023
	Institute of Communications Research Graduate Travel Grant	2022–2025
	Prime Minister’s Scholarship, Government of India	2012
SELECTED CONFERENCE TALKS	Bhalla, S. (2026). Read All Around It: The Regional Organization of Newspaper Markets. <i>Political Communication Section: Midwest Political Science Association</i> . [Full Paper] Bhalla, S. (2026). Following the News: Polarization and the Networked Structure of Attention. <i>Information Systems Division: International Communication Association</i> . [Full Paper] – Top Paper Prize	

Bhalla, S., J. Henrichsen & B. Toff (2026). When Machines Start Writing: Assessing the Impact of Generative AI on Journalism Labor Markets. *Computational Methods Division: International Communication Association*.. [Full Paper]

Bhalla, S. (2025). Paper Trails: Place, proximity and spillovers in local news ecosystems. *Political Communication Section: American Political Science Association*. [Full Paper; not presented given travel restrictions]

Bhalla, S. & Maggie Zhang (2025). Competitors or Complements? Examining the Effect of Human-AI Interaction on Human-Human Interaction. *Human-Machine Communication Division: International Communication Association*. [Full Paper]

Bhalla, S. & H. Taneja (2024). Dissecting Selectivity in a fragmented media environment: A novel approach. *APSA Political Communication Preconference*.

Bhalla, S. & H. Taneja (2024). Entwined Realms: Media Contexts and Information Choice. *American Political Science Association*. [iPoster]

Bhalla, S., R. Ray & H. Taneja (2024). When News is Entertainment. *International Communication Division: AEJMC*, Philadelphia, PA. [Poster]

Bhalla, S. & H. Taneja (2024). Beyond Preferences: Contextual Influences on News Diets in High-Choice Environments. *Political Communication Division: AEJMC*, Philadelphia, PA. [Poster]

Bhalla, S. & H. Taneja (2024). Entwined Realms: Examining Media Contexts and News Choice. *A Computational Turn in Journalism: ICA 2024 Preconference*, Singapore/Virtual.

Bhalla, S., M. Nelson & M. Spikes (2023). Context Matters: Teachers Talk Media Literacy in the Classroom. *Mass Communication Division: International Communication Association*, Toronto, Canada. [Full paper]

Bhalla, S., R. Ray & H. Taneja (2022). Foregrounding contexts in disinformation studies: A study on the failure of fact-checking in India. *What Comes After Disinformation Studies? ICA Preconference*, Paris, France.

Ray, R., **Sakshi Bhalla** & H. Taneja (2022). Fact checkers fail to overcome partisan divides in two of the world's largest democracies. *Political Communication Division: International Communication Association*, Paris, France. [Full Paper]

Bhalla, S. (2021). Foregrounding Space and context: A discursive study of fact-checking in India. *South Asia Communication Association: AEJMC*, Virtual.

Ray, R., **Sakshi Bhalla** & H. Taneja (2021). Do fact-checkers overcome partisan divides: An investigation of Indian Twitter users. *International Communication Association*, Virtual. [Full paper]

	Bhalla, S. (2018). The Global in the Local: Inter-cultural Translation in the Backdrop of Global Advertising. <i>International Symposium on Linguistics Across Disciplines</i>, Aligarh Muslim University, India. [Full paper]	
WORKSHOPS	Bhalla, S. (2025). Following the News: Polarization and the Networked Structure of Attention. <i>PolNet & PaCSS, 2025</i>, Cambridge, CA. Bhalla, S. (2024). Diffused News Cultures: Explaining news cultures through spatial relationships. <i>Local Journalism Researchers Workshop</i>, Chapel-Hill, NC.	
PRESENTATIONS	Bhalla, S. (2024). Navigating Narratives: Selective Exposure to Indian Journalists. <i>Social Media and Society in India</i>, Ann Arbor, MI/Virtual. Bhalla, S. (2022). How politics and platforms skew media literacy instruction. <i>Institute of Communications Research</i>, University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign. Bhalla, S. (2021). Ahirani: A Sociolinguistic Profile. <i>Centre for South Asian and Middle Eastern Studies</i>, University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign. Bhalla, S. (2021). Foregrounding Space and context: A discursive study of fact-checking in India. <i>The Great Mediation</i> (University of Chicago). Bhalla, S. (2019). The Technological Mediation of Political Rhetoric on Twitter. <i>Mediated Campaigns and Unmediated Politics in Millennial India</i>, Centre de Sciences Humaines, New Delhi.	
INVITED TALKS	Bhalla, S. (2025). Classroom contexts: Teachers talk teaching media literacy. Media Education Lab. Bhalla, S. (2024). News and Information Consumption in the Contemporary Media Environment: Are Fact-Checkers Enough? Jio Institute Masterclass.	
TEACHING	Pre-doctoral Fellow, University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign • Lead Teaching Assistant: Foundations of Data Curation (CS/IS 598) • Instructor of Record: Audience Analysis (ADV 483) • Teaching Assistant: Data Management, Curation & Reproducibility (IS 477); Intro to Popular TV and Movies (MACS 100); Intro to Advertising (ADV 150)	2021–present
	Graduate Student Mentor, URAP, University of Illinois • Introduced undergraduates to research on media, information and politics. • Jury member, Social Issues & Policy and Social Science & Human Behavior panels, Undergraduate Research Symposium 2025 & 2026.	2022–present

OTHER RESEARCH EXPERIENCE	IMEDIA Group , University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign Research Assistant Examined media literacy approaches used by high-school teachers in Illinois through semi-structured interviews.	2021–present Champaign, IL
	Open Markets Institute (Center for Liberty and Journalism) Student Researcher Assisted the Illinois Project team; collected data for multiple research projects.	Jun–Aug 2021 Washington, DC
	Indian Council of Social Science Research (ICSSR) Research Analyst Developed surveys and interview protocols, oversaw participant recruitment, and coordinated the project team. Findings published in <i>Communication, Culture & Critique</i> .	Jan–Apr 2021 New Delhi, India
	Indraprastha Institute of Information & Technology (IIIT-New Delhi) Research Assistant Studied media parallelism and framing of policy discourse across news publications during the General Election of 2019 in India.	2019–20 New Delhi, India
ADDITIONAL TRAINING	Chicago School of Experimental Economics Summer Workshop	2025
	Methodology Center at Purdue Summer Institute	2025
	Computational Linguistics Bootcamp, IIT Delhi	2019
	Short-term course on Role of Media in Conflict and Peace	2014
	Short-term course on Journalism as a Public Good	2014
	Short-term course on Film Appreciation	2013
DATA SCIENCE & TECH	Languages & Tools: R (proficient), Python (intermediate), HTML/CSS (intermediate), $\text{\LaTeX}$, QGIS/ArcGIS Statistical Modelling: Statistical inference, causal inference, network analysis and spatial econometrics, statistical learning	
SERVICE TO THE DEPARTMENT	ICR Graduate Student Conference: Organizing Team & Reviewer	2023
	ICR Graduate Student Representative	2023–24
SERVICE TO THE DISCIPLINE	Reviewing for annual conferences: International Communication Association (Political Communication, Computational Methods, Journalism Studies, and Human-Machine Communication divisions)	

Reviewing for journals: *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications – Nature; Journalism Studies; New Media & Society*

IN THE MEDIA	Interview with Centre for Innovation & Sustainability in Local Media. Q&A with media and politics researcher, Sakshi Bhalla . Also syndicated by <i>Editor & Publisher</i> . Report by University of Illinois News Bureau: Mandatory media literacy education in Illinois schools impaired by digital divides .	
NON-ACADEMIC EXPERIENCE	Thinkstr Consultancy Campaign Strategy (<i>Promoted to Senior</i>)	Mar 2016–Jul 2018 Gurgaon, India
	• Spearheaded strategic communication for NITI Aayog (Government of India), including the nationwide launch of digital payments in a 100-day campaign across 100 Indian cities. • Led the campaigns driving the commercial rollout of UPI (Unified Payments Interface) system and BHIM app, leading to nationwide adoption and digital onboarding. • The app achieved 10 million downloads within 10 days of launch, and over 17 million in the first two months.	
	D. E. Shaw & Co. Associate	Jun 2015–Feb 2016 Hyderabad, India
	Evaluated internal program processes and assisted with implementation strategies across multiple teams, supporting high-volume workflows.	
INTERNSHIPS & PROJECTS	The Coca-Cola Company (India and Southwest Asia HQ) Summer Intern	Summer 2014 Gurgaon, India
	Worked with the Public Affairs and Communication Department; supported corporate responsibility initiatives across Marketing and Public Affairs.	
PROFESSIONAL AFFILIATIONS	Member, International Communication Association Member, American Political Science Association Affiliate, Center for Information, Technology, and Public Life (CITAP)	
LANGUAGES	Native/Proficient: English, Hindi, Punjabi; Beginner: Ahirani	

Last updated: August 9, 2026